

SUCCESS MANTRA

Follow your own path and you will be able to achieve your goal

biggest OBSTACLE

A government that could not distinguish between a winery and a distillery

turning POINT

Only after Taj hotels and Indigo restaurant stocked them did Sula wines catch on in India



BHASKAR PAUL

RAJEEV
SAMANT

41, VINTNER
CEO, SULA WINES
INVESTMENT IN 1998 Rs 5 crore
TURNOVER IN 2008 Rs 70 crore

THE WHOLE VINE YARDS

When Elizabeth Hurley's businessman husband Arun Nayar uncorked a bottle of Indian wine on her 40th birthday bash in 2005, Sula had arrived on the global Page 3. As had the man behind Sula, Nayar's former schoolmate, Rajeev Samant.

Years ago, Samant travelled to Stanford University for a degree in engineering. But a love for wines made Samant quit his high-flying Oracle job in 1996 to make wine in India, firm in his resolve to turn his 30-acre family estate at Nashik into a vineyard. "Indian wines here were acidic, harsh, inconsistent and tasted like cheap Old World produce," says the Mumbai-based CEO of Sula Wines.

In 1997, Samant planted his vineyards with grape varieties like Californian Chenin Blanc and French Sauvignon Blanc. He partnered with Californian winemaker Kerry Damskey to bring in New World winemaking techniques. With a capital of Rs 5 crore, raised from family and friends, Samant set up his first winery in Nashik and celebrated his first crushing season the next year. But starting production was no cakewalk. Samant obtained a winery licence after a two-year struggle. "They couldn't tell the difference between a winery and a distillery," he says. Loans weren't easy either.

In 2000, Samant finally produced his first batch of 5,000 cases. But the first year sales didn't cross even one truck-load, which is 6,000 bottles. "I often wondered if I had made a mistake," he says. Samant then travelled across Mumbai hotels and restaurants promoting his wines. It was only after Taj hotels and Rahul Akerkar's Indigo restaurant stocked the wines that Sula caught on. Samant named his brand Sula, short for his mother's name, Sulabha. He used a picture of *surya* as the logo and proudly announced on the label that the wine was produced in India. "It was a risk. But it worked," explains Samant. After the wine boom of 2002, there was no looking back for Samant.

In 2008, Sula produced 2.5 lakh cases of wine and had a turnover of Rs 70 crore. Today, its stable has six varieties and it distributes two international brands. It recently launched a cheaper wine brand Samsara. Samant supports the local rural economy by buying grapes from 300 contract farmers, also generating employment for 2,000 people.

Guests can visit the Sula vineyards on wine tours, participate in the annual crushing festival and sample the wines. As Samant's plans mature and grow, the Sula *surya* is sparkling bright on India's wine horizon.

by Aditi Pal